

**Allelonomy:
Autonomy After Sovereignty**

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Abstract

Modernity's exit from guardianship produced a figure it did not intend: the sovereign chooser, whose capacities, preferences, and menu of options were formed by institutions and technical systems that have vanished from the chooser's self-description, and who therefore experiences produced choices as original self-authorship, epistemic dependence as humiliation, and collective obligation as intrusion. This paper names the position beyond both the ward and the sovereign. Allelonymy, from *allelon*, one another, and *nomos*, law, is self-rule through one another: the capacity of distinct persons to govern themselves through reciprocal, contestable, and non-dominating relations that also participate in forming them. The word has a documented prior use for mutual dependence, and mutual dependence alone is nothing, since a cartel and a conspiracy network are also mutually dependent; four conditions make dependence emancipatory, and the paper's simulation prices each by deleting it. In a two-site formation loop where children's capacities are partly made by the site that raises them, mild private preference for better peers stratifies the population with no planner and no changed law, a capacity gap of 0.28 by generation 25; a standing commitment by part of the advantaged to stay cuts the gap to 0.13 at a measured private cost of 0.04 per committed family per generation, so recursive responsibility is real and it is not free. In an institution maintained by the voice of its articulate members, free exit after a scandal removes exactly those members, and quality spirals from 0.6 to the floor at 0.05, inherited by everyone who could not leave; forbidding exit holds quality at 0.95, and accountable exit, which keeps 0.6 of a leaver's contribution and voice attached, stabilizes quality at 0.54 while 17 of 100 members still leave: choice survives, and so does the institution. In an epistemic world where an expert institution is right 0.9 of the time when honest and 0.35 when captured, and one person's research alone is right 0.62 of the time, the ward scores 0.9 and 0.35, tracking the institution all the way down; the sovereign scores 0.62 everywhere; the herd, dependence without distinction, reproduces the ward's numbers with extra steps; and the allelonymic configuration, 21 independent signals pooled, the institution audited when the pool disagrees, scores 0.9 honest and 0.77 captured. Delete non-domination, letting the institution suppress the pool, and the same configuration returns to 0.35. Freedom, on this account, is neither obedience nor autarky. It is the power to participate in governing the relations through which one becomes capable of acting at all.

The produced sovereign

A patient refuses a treatment because a video refuted the physician. A parent moves a child to the better school and calls the aggregate result, which is a sorted city, nobody's doing. A citizen asks why obligations he never personally signed should bind him, while standing inside a security, a currency, and a language he never built. The figure underneath these scenes is the same, and this paper calls it the produced sovereign: a person whose capacities were cultivated by schools, whose preferences were patterned by a class position, whose attention is curated by machines, whose knowledge is almost entirely testimony, and who has been taught to describe this ensemble as self-authorship, so that every dependence reads as an insult and every shared claim as a trespass.

The paper's subject is the loop this figure cannot see. Conditions of formation produce capacities

for judgment; capacities issue in choices; choices aggregate into sorting; sorting becomes the next generation's conditions of formation. Sovereignty discourse keeps the middle term, the choosing, and erases the arrows on both sides. The erasure is the theory's whole error, and correcting it does not return anyone to guardianship. Between the ward, who is governed through dependencies he cannot contest, and the sovereign, who denies that dependence has any claim on him, there is a third position, and it needs a name, a definition, and numbers. The name is allelonomy. The definition and the numbers follow.

The exit from tutelage

Kant's answer to the question of enlightenment defined immaturity as the inability to use one's own understanding without another's guidance, called it self-incurred where it rests on cowardice rather than incapacity, and issued the imperative: *sapere aude* (Kant, 1784). The exit from tutelage is the founding scene of the modern person, and nothing in this paper retracts it. What the scene never contained is the solitary thinker. Kant's own essay ties enlightenment to the public use of reason, argument offered to a reading world; the capacity to judge is cultivated by teachers, exercised in languages nobody invented alone, and checked against others. Reasoning for oneself was never reasoning by oneself. The relational-autonomy literature made the point systematic: the competencies that constitute autonomy, self-trust, self-knowledge, the ability to weigh reasons, are developed and sustained inside relations and institutions, which can nourish them and can also destroy them (Mackenzie and Stoljar, 2000). The question that matters is never whether a person depends. It is whether the dependencies are the kind that produce a judge or the kind that produce a subject.

The mutation into sovereignty

Between the Enlightenment's self-governing person and the contemporary sovereign chooser lies a mutation with identifiable stages. Mill's harm principle drew a circle around the individual within which society has no jurisdiction (Mill, 1859), a defensible boundary that later readers inflated from a protection into a metaphysics: the person as a bounded realm whose interior generates its own law. The claim of self-government became a claim of final jurisdiction, and the claim of final jurisdiction became a claim of exemption, the right to decide, for oneself, when shared rules and shared facts apply. That last step borrows its logic from political theology: the sovereign is the one who decides the exception, and the modern self has been invited to be exactly that, each person a small state entitled to suspend the common order at its own border.

The republican tradition had already rejected the equation of freedom with this kind of mastery. Arendt argued that freedom exists only among plural agents, and that the pursuit of sovereignty, mastery over the conditions of action, is the pursuit of something no acting being can have, since action always lands in a web of other actors (Arendt, 1961). Pettit's non-domination relocates unfreedom from interference to arbitrary power: a person is unfree when another holds uncontrolled power over her conditions of action, and free when that power is checked, whether or not it is ever exercised (Pettit, 1999). Balibar's equaliberty binds the two: liberty cannot be detached from the

equal capacity of others to exercise and contest it (Balibar, 2014). All three describe freedom as a position inside relations, and sovereignty as the fantasy of a position outside them.

How the chooser is made

The sovereign's missing history is documented. Foucault's subjectivation names the processes by which institutions produce the very subjects who then experience themselves as prior to institutions (Foucault, 1982). Bourdieu's habitus shows preference itself as deposit: the tastes, aspirations, and senses of the possible that a class position lays down in a body, which then chooses, freely and predictably (Bourdieu, 1984). Stiegler adds the technical layer: memory and attention are partly externalized into inherited supports, so the instruments a generation thinks with are artifacts it did not make (Stiegler, 1998). Deleuze's control societies describe the contemporary form: power as continuous modulation, scores, rankings, feeds, and access conditions that shape conduct without ever issuing a command (Deleuze, 1992). And Boltanski and Chiapello traced the neatest turn: the anti-authoritarian critique of the 1960s, be no one's subordinate, define yourself, was absorbed by the system it attacked and returned as a job description, the entrepreneurial self, obliged to perpetual self-management, whose failures are its own fault by definition (Boltanski and Chiapello, 2005). Sloterdijk's provocation about anthropotechnics, that humanism was always a practice of forming humans and the question is only who runs the workshop, belongs here as one bounded observation (Sloterdijk, 2009): formation is not the scandal; disavowed formation is.

None of these authors licenses the inference the produced sovereign draws from them when he encounters them secondhand, that because the self is produced, every institution is a fraud and every expert a power play. That inference has its own section below. What the production literature establishes is narrower and firmer: the chooser, the menu, and the experience of choosing all have histories, and a politics that starts at the moment of choice has started too late.

Three mechanisms, built

The paper's claims about the loop are simulable, and the simulation builds the three domains where the argument lives. All numbers below are facts about the model's geometry; nothing is an empirical estimate, and the construction is stated so the reader can audit what follows from what. In the first mechanism, 1000 agents live in two developmental sites; parents choose sites under a mild preference for the better peer environment, subject to affordability; children's capacities are formed 0.55 by their parent, 0.45 by their site, plus noise. In the second, an institution's quality is maintained by the voice of its 30 most articulate members against a constant decay, funding follows enrollment, and a scandal at period 10 knocks quality down by 0.25. In the third, agents form beliefs about questions of fact under an expert institution that is right 0.9 of the time when honest and 0.35 when captured, with private research right 0.62 of the time and a pool of 21 potential independent signals.

Private choice, public selection

Schelling proved the pattern half a century ago: mild local preferences, nobody wanting more than a modestly better neighborhood, generate strong aggregate segregation that no participant intended or wants (Schelling, 1971). The model's formation loop adds the developmental arrow: the sites people sort into are also the sites that make the next generation's capacities. Under sovereign choice, every affordable move toward the better peer environment made, the capacity gap between the two sites goes from nothing to 0.28 in 25 generations. No planner exists, no law changes, no one discriminates. The sort is the sum of reasonable private acts, and its product is a stratification of capacities themselves, which then buys the next round of sorting: the loop closing.

Young's social connection model says what responsibility looks like in this structure: where an injustice is produced by the ordinary, legal acts of many connected participants, responsibility does not require a guilty author; it falls, forward-looking and political, on the participants whose practices reproduce the outcome (Young, 2006). The model gives her claim a price tag. In the allelonomic regime, a standing commitment by 0.6 of the advantaged lineages to stay, made because they count what their aggregated moves reproduce, cuts the final gap to 0.13, a factor of 2.2. The commitment costs its bearers 0.04 of formation per family per generation, forgone peer advantage for their own children, and the model reports the cost instead of hiding it, because a responsibility that pretends to be free is a slogan. The result is uncomfortable in both directions: the sovereign regime stratifies a society without a single villain, and the remedy asks real people to spend their children's marginal advantage on other people's children.

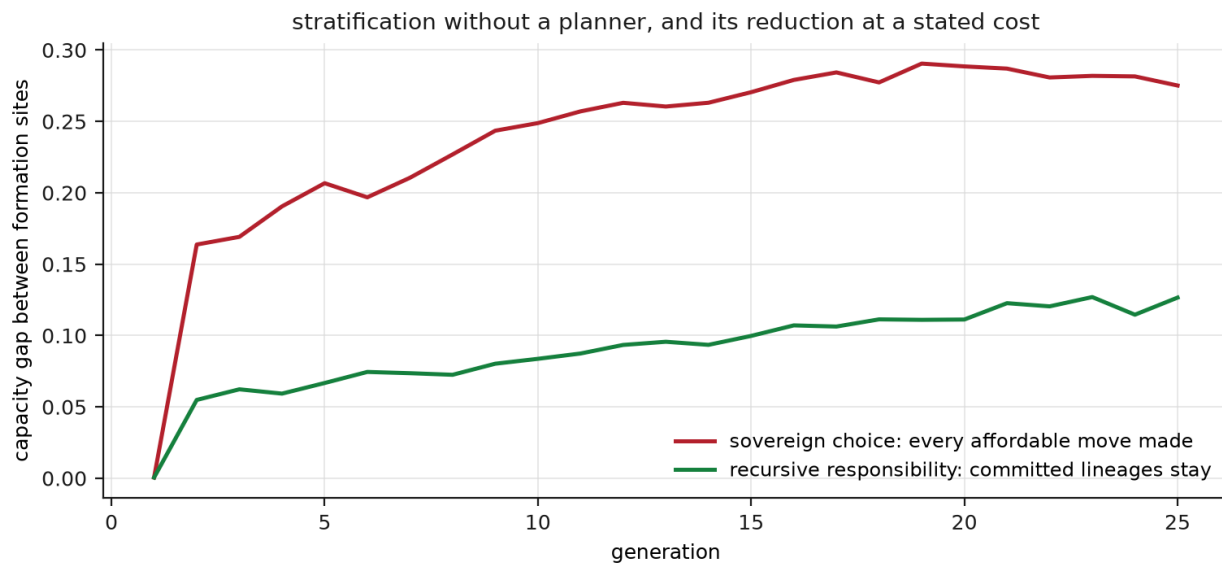


Figure 1: The formation loop. Under sovereign choice the capacity gap between sites reaches 0.28 in 25 generations with no planner; under a standing commitment by part of the advantaged it holds near 0.13, at a measured cost to the committed.

Exit, voice, and who inherits the wreck

Hirschman's triad organizes the second mechanism: members of a declining institution can exit, taking their custom elsewhere, or exercise voice, staying to repair it, and exit by those best equipped for voice can remove precisely the feedback the institution needed (Hirschman, 1970). The model stages his warning. After the scandal, quality falls below the exit standard of the resourced. Where exit is free, the 34 members who can afford alternatives leave; the articulate members are the same people; voice goes to zero, funding follows enrollment down, and quality spirals from 0.6 to the floor of 0.05, where it is inherited, permanently, by the 66 members who never had the resources to leave. Nothing in the spiral was anyone's fault at the moment they did it. Each exit was the reasonable act of a sovereign consumer, and the aggregate is an abandoned institution wearing the costume of freedom.

The two comparison regimes locate the repair. Forbidding exit holds quality at 0.95, voice doing its work, and the price appears elsewhere: the members are wards of the institution, and the epistemic section below shows what wards inherit when an institution itself goes wrong. Accountable exit is the allelonomic design: leaving is permitted and keeps 0.6 of the leaver's contribution and voice attached, the way a citizen who changes schools does not thereby exit the school system's tax base or its politics. Under it, 17 members still leave, choice survives, and quality stabilizes at 0.54. The design's content is the paper's general claim in miniature: the alternative to sovereign exit is neither captivity nor loyalty oaths; it is exit that remains answerable to the common thing it exits from.

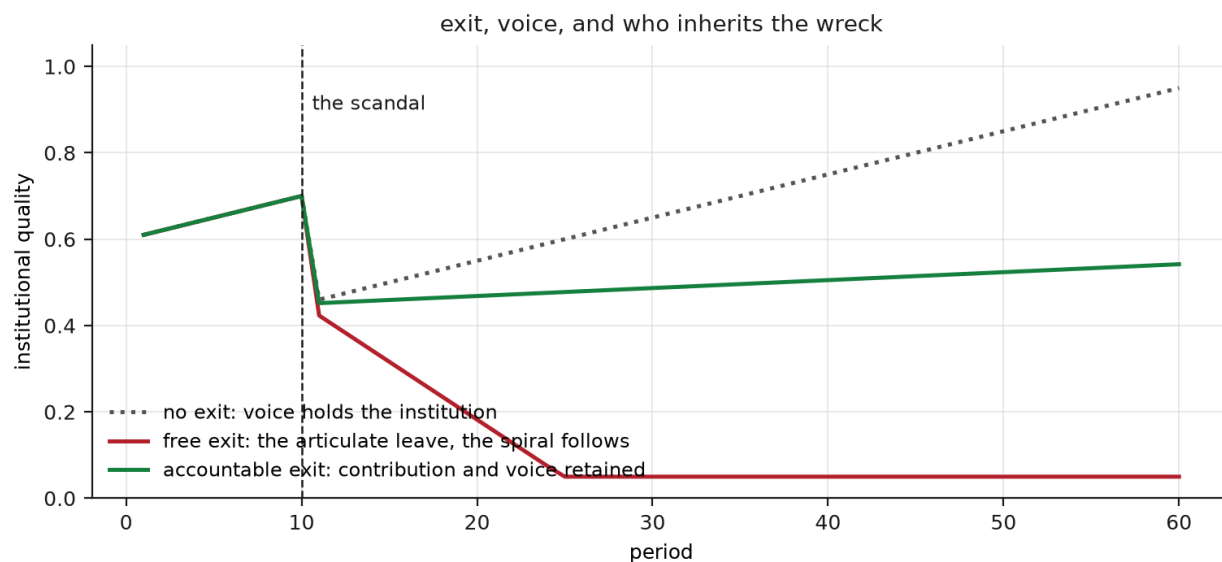


Figure 2: The institution after the scandal. Free exit removes the articulate and quality spirals to the floor the immobile inherit; no exit holds quality but makes wards; accountable exit keeps choice and the institution alive at once.

Counterfeit epistemic sovereignty

The produced sovereign's deepest conviction is epistemic: I looked into it myself. Hardwig showed decades ago that this posture misdescribes even science from the inside, since a rational epistemic life consists mostly of justified dependence on others who know what one cannot check (Hardwig, 1985), and Polanyi showed that much of what an expert knows is tacit, unstatable in propositions the layman could audit (Polanyi, 1966). The infrastructure of a modern belief, instruments, archives, peer networks, platforms and their rankings, is invisible in the first person; the sovereign researcher experiences its outputs as his own findings. Latour named the perverse turn by which the critical tradition armed this figure: techniques built to show how facts are constructed were repurposed to conclude that constructed means fake, so that discovering an institution behind a claim now counts as refuting the claim (Latour, 2004). Nguyen's echo chambers complete the picture: structures that do not merely omit contrary voices but pre-discredit them, so that exposure to rebuttal strengthens the member's confidence (Nguyen, 2020). And where the sovereign researcher thinks he is escaping manipulation, he frequently walks into it, since organized interests manufacture doubt on schedule, a documented industry from tobacco to climate (Oreskes and Conway, 2010).

The model's grid states the whole predicament in eight numbers. The ward, adopting the institution's answer, scores 0.9 under an honest institution and 0.35 under a captured one: deference tracks its institution all the way down, which is the true content of the sovereign's suspicion and the reason commanded trust deserves to fail. The sovereign, researching alone, scores 0.62 in both worlds: independence purchased at the price of being mediocre everywhere, invulnerable to capture because there is so little to capture. The herd, dependence without distinction, everyone deferring to whatever speaks loudest, reproduces the ward's numbers, 0.9 and 0.35, which is worth a plain sentence: a crowd that follows the follower is one ward with many bodies, and interdependence as such is nothing to celebrate. The allelonomic configuration holds the four conditions at once. Distinction: 21 members keep independent private signals, whose pooled majority alone is right 0.87 of the time. Contestability: when the pool disagrees with the institution, an audit fires with sensitivity 0.8. Non-domination: the institution cannot suppress the pool. The result is 0.9 under honesty and 0.77 under capture: nearly nothing sacrificed in the good world, most of the loss repaired in the bad one. Delete non-domination, letting the institution silence its auditors, and the identical architecture returns 0.35 under capture, the ward's number: the conditions are jointly necessary, and the grid prices each by deletion.

This is the arithmetic behind O'Neill's dictum that the proper aim is trustworthiness rather than trust (O'Neill, 2002), behind Longino's account of objectivity as organized criticism rather than individual purity (Longino, 1990), and behind Collins and Evans's insistence that expertise is real, unequally distributed, and in need of institutions that neither level it nor enthrone it (Collins and Evans, 2002). Fricker's warning patrols the pool itself: whose signals get counted, and whose are discounted in advance, is a question of justice inside the epistemic machinery, since credibility can be systematically misassigned (Fricker, 2007). The politics of knowledge that follows is neither restored deference nor universal suspicion. It is the construction of institutions that are accurate

when honest, exposable when captured, and structurally incapable of silencing the people who would notice.

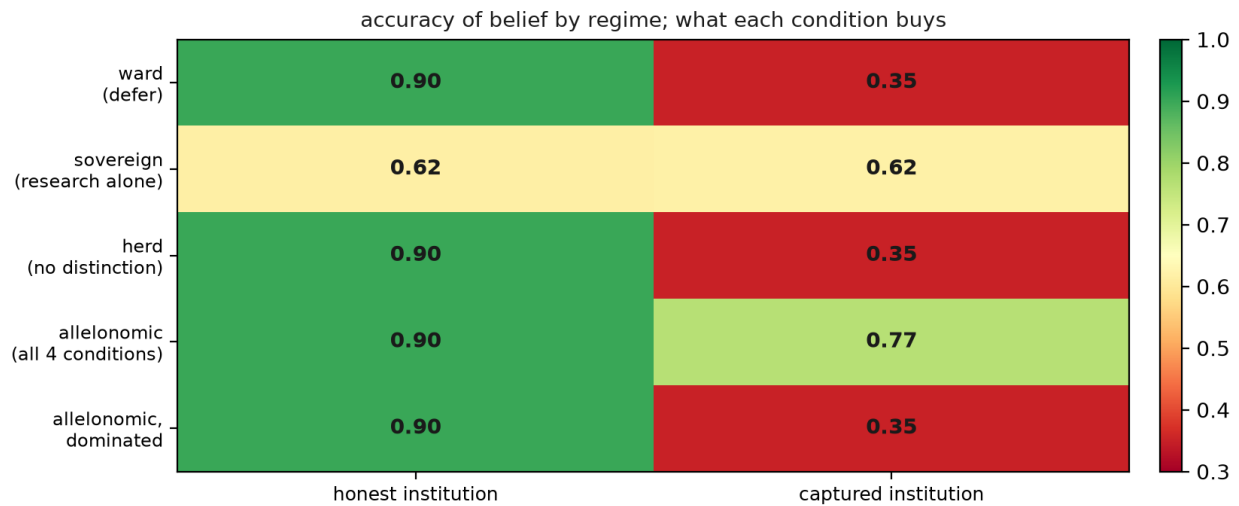


Figure 3: Accuracy by regime. Deference tracks the institution down; solitary research is mediocre everywhere; the herd is a ward with extra steps; the allelonymic configuration survives capture, and loses that property the moment the institution can suppress its auditors.

The logic of care

Medicine is where the ward and the sovereign meet daily, and where both fail people concretely. Mol's ethnography of diabetes care found that the consumer frame, options presented, preference exercised, misdescribes what good treatment is: care is iterative, collaborative, materially embedded, and revised as bodies respond, and the crucial question is what arrangement lets good knowledge and good adjustment emerge over time (Mol, 2008). Kittay grounds the point in the species: dependency is the human condition's baseline, bracketed by infancy and age and never absent between them, sustained by labor that the sovereign self-description renders invisible (Kittay, 1999). And the market frame fails on its own terms: Stiglitz's information economics established that transactions between unequally informed parties do not behave like the sovereign-consumer picture, and a clinic is the extreme case of asymmetric information (Stiglitz, 2002).

The allelonymic patient is what the triad looks like in a body. The physician holds causal knowledge the patient cannot audit; the patient holds first-person knowledge and the authority over which burdens to accept; the relation works when the asymmetry of competence is combined with symmetry of standing, each side correctable by the other in its own register. Epistemic asymmetry without political subordination: the clinical version of the whole paper.

Allelonymy

The word has a genealogy, and the definition begins by crediting it. Naniwada used allelonymy against the picture of reality as a collection of separate autonomous entities, for the mutual depen-

dence of things (Naniwada, 1993). The Greek carries the structure the concept needs: *allelon*, one another, in the slot where *autos*, the self, sits in autonomy. The law-through-one-another. What the prior use lacks, and the herding cell of the grid demonstrates the lack, is any distinction between dependence that emancipates and dependence that swallows: a caste order, an abusive marriage, and a conspiracy network are all mutually dependent. The paper's definition therefore binds the word to four conditions, and the simulation has priced each. Distinction: persons remain independent centers of judgment; delete it and the pool becomes the herd. Contestability: the relations and institutions that form people are open to challenge and revision; delete it and the audit never fires. Non-domination: no party holds uncontrolled power over the conditions of another's agency; delete it and the suppressed pool changes nothing. Recursive responsibility: agents answer for what their aggregated choices reproduce; delete it and the formation loop stratifies on schedule. Allelonymy is constitutive dependence made visible, contestable, and jointly governable.

The nearby names fail for reasons worth one sentence each. Relational autonomy is correct and names a corrective rather than a position. Coauthorship, the strongest rival, overstates intention: language, biology, and aggregate effects are constitutive without being anyone's manuscript. Illich's conviviality comes close, individual freedom realized in personal interdependence, and sounds too much like harmony for a concept whose core is contestation (Illich, 1973). The institutional face of allelonymy already exists in fragments: Castoriadis's autonomous society, which knows its institutions as its own revisable creations and questions them explicitly (Castoriadis, 1987); Dewey's public, called into being by the consequences of transactions and constituted by organized inquiry into them (Dewey, 1927); Ostrom's polycentric governance, self-rule neither by the single center nor by the atomized market (Ostrom, 1990). What the fragments share is the shape: order produced among its subjects, revisable by them, owned by none of them.

The triad can now be stated in full. Heteronomy: another governs me; the ward's condition, and its pathology is that the dependencies cannot be contested. Sovereign autonomy: I govern myself and dependence has no legitimate claim; the produced sovereign's condition, and its pathology is that the self-description is false, so the dependencies govern unacknowledged, which is the ward's condition wearing a crown. Allelonymy: we become capable of self-government through one another, and the relations that make us capable are themselves under our joint, contested, revisable government. The mature person on this account defers without surrendering judgment, contests institutions without concluding that institutions are frauds, chooses while answering for what the choices of the many like her reproduce, and treats her own formation as a thing to be examined rather than a humiliation to be denied.

Objections

The conformity objection says that a self ruled through others is a self dissolved into them. The grid answers it with a number: the regime that dissolves distinction, the herd, is the worst configuration on the board, and the allelonomic regime beats it precisely by keeping every member's signal independent. Allelonymy requires stubborn individuals; it is the organization of their stub-

bornness, and a consensus that arrives too easily is evidence against the process that produced it.

The expertise objection says that flattening the doctor and the patient, the climatologist and the commenter, is epistemic catastrophe. It is, and nothing here flattens them. The allelonomic design preserves asymmetric competence, defers to it at full accuracy while the institution deserves it, and adds only the machinery that catches the case where the competent institution has been captured. Deference plus audit outperforms both blind deference and universal suspicion in the model's own arithmetic.

The novelty objection says this is relational autonomy renamed. The response is the definition's second half: relational autonomy describes how autonomy is socially constituted; allelonomy adds the government of the constituting relations, the four conditions, and their joint necessity, which the deletions price separately. A name earns itself when it holds together claims that otherwise travel apart, and the word is offered on that basis: the position needed a flag its components could gather under.

The cost objection says the responsibility term asks the advantaged for their children's margin, and that no one will pay it. The model does not settle whether they will; it establishes what the payment buys, a halving of the stratification of formation itself, and it refuses to advertise the price as zero. Politics begins where the price is stated.

After sovereignty

The ward is governed through dependencies he cannot contest. The sovereign denies that dependence has any claim on him, and is governed through his dependencies anyway, unacknowledged, which is the older condition returned in costume. The allelonomic person is what maturity looks like once the loop is admitted: formed, and a former; dependent, and a governor of dependencies; one another's condition of possibility, holding that condition open to question. Enlightenment's imperative does not retire on this account; it completes. Have the courage to use your own understanding, and have the candor to know what built it, who maintains it, and what your uses of it, summed with everyone else's, are building next.

Reproducibility

The simulation, its three figures, and every model number quoted above regenerate from one command in the paper's repository (`simulation/run_all.py`; seeded, bit-for-bit reproducible). Thirteen invariants, among them stratification arising without a planner, the responsibility commitment's nonzero price, the exit spiral and its stabilization under accountable exit, the ward's collapse under a captured institution, the herd's reproduction of the ward's numbers, the allelonomic configuration's survival of capture, and the loss of that survival when non-domination is deleted, fail the run loudly if broken.

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